



German contrition

In December 1970 the West German chancellor Willy Brandt visited Poland; at the Warsaw Ghetto memorial, he expressed sorrow for Nazi war crimes, and knelt in homage to the victims.

western zones of occupation, which will become their future constitution.

1949 Germany is divided as the three western zones are merged into the German Federal Republic, with its capital in Bonn, while the Soviet zone becomes the communist German Democratic Republic with its capital in East Berlin. Konrad Adenauer is the first West German chancellor (until 1963). Walter Ulbricht is General Secretary of the East German Communist Party until 1971, when he is succeeded by Erich Honecker.

1951 West Germany joins its historic enemy, France, as well as Italy and the Low Countries, in the European Coal and Steel Community, the first step to creating the European Union. Further steps toward European integration begin.

1953 Strikes and rioting in East Berlin against communist rule as thousands of refugees pour through the border into West Berlin seeking a better life.

1955 West Germany joins NATO; East Germany joins the Warsaw Pact as Cold War divisions harden in Europe.

1957 West Germany signs the Treaty of Rome setting up the European Economic Community.

1961 Berlin Wall built to seal off West Berlin; the US responds by moving a large tank division into the city. The visit of US president John F. Kennedy to the city in June 1963, when he gives his famous *Ich bin ein Berliner* ("I am a Berliner") speech further raises morale in the city.

1963 Konrad Adenauer steps down as West German chancellor and is succeeded by Ludwig Erhard.

1966–69 West German grand coalition of CDU and SPD parties, headed by Kurt Georg Kiesinger.

1969–82 SPD-led West German coalition governments with the Free Democratic Party (FDP) under Willy Brandt (1969–74) and Helmut Schmidt (1974–82).

1970 West Germany signs peace treaties with the USSR and Poland, recognizing their post-war borders and ending German claims to territories it lost at the end of World War II. For his work in promoting peace in Europe, and for his policy of "Ostpolitik," "east policy" or detente with Eastern Europe, Brandt is awarded the 1971 Nobel Peace Prize.

1972 West and East Germany sign a treaty of mutual recognition. Agreements with the USSR about access to West Berlin reduce tensions in and around the city.

1973 Both Germanies join the UN.

1974 Willy Brandt is forced to resign after an East German spy is found working as a personal aide in his office.

1982 Helmut Kohl becomes West German chancellor at the head of a CDU–FDP coalition.

1988 In a speech to the UN, the Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev signals the end of Soviet domination of Eastern Europe, including East Germany, by withdrawing Soviet troops and giving states "freedom of choice" over their future.

1989 As Hungary dismantles its fortified border with Austria, thus breaking down the Iron Curtain, thousands of East Germans pour through seeking a new life in the West. At first the East German government does not reduce its hardline rule, but it is told to change by Gorbachev. As massive, peaceful protests break out across East Germany, notably in Dresden, the border is opened and Berliners begin to dismantle the Berlin Wall.

1990 Reunification of Germany as the USSR and the other wartime allies raise no objections. East and West Germany sign a treaty extending the West German currency and its economic, monetary, and social legislation to East Germany. The East German parliament votes for union as the five East German länder (states) join the Federal Republic. The first all-German elections held since 1933 result in a Kohl-led government.

1996 Rising concern over jobs as Germany struggles to reintegrate the poor parts of former East Germany into the economy, despite massive investment in the region to overcome years of communist rule and environmental degradation.

1998 Gerhard Schröder heads a coalition of SPD and Greens.

1999 For the first time since World War II, German troops take part in military activities abroad, participating in the NATO action against Serbia. In 2001 Germany is given command of the NATO peacekeeping mission in Macedonia, while German troops are also involved in

GERMANY

EAST GERMANY

The five former eastern provinces of Germany were occupied by Soviet forces after World War II. A people's assembly meeting in East Berlin in 1948–49 prepared a constitution for the new state, which came into being on October 7, 1949, as the German Democratic Republic.

The new state embarked on a program of "socialist construction" led by the Socialist Unity Party of Walter Ulbricht. Industry was nationalized and agriculture collectivized, while reparations were made to the USSR for the cost of the war. The resulting hardship led to riots and strikes in 1953, which were put down with Soviet troops and tanks.

During the 1950s, economic differences between East and West Germany grew,

leading many East Germans to flee through West Berlin in search of a better life. This outlet to the West was sealed in 1961 with the building of the Berlin Wall.

Relations between East and West Germany improved during the 1970s, with the East German parliament removing all references to reunification of Germany from its constitution in 1974. However, a new exodus of East Germans through Hungary to the west as the Iron Curtain collapsed in 1989 threatened communist rule. Non-communists entered the government, but the fall of the Berlin Wall and the collapse of communism in Eastern Europe spelled the end of East Germany, which united with the west in 1990. Below, East Berliners mark May 1 with a march celebrating the heroes of communism.



peacekeeping in Afghanistan after 2002. Germany has also been a leading light in the EU's Rapid Reaction Force, providing almost half its personnel.

1999 The Federal Assembly and the rest of the German government move from Bonn back to Berlin.

2000 Helmut Kohl is disgraced in a party funding scandal.

2002 Germany abandons the deutschmark—the symbol of its post-war regeneration—in favor of the euro.

2002 Edmund Stoiber, leader of the CDU's sister party, the Bavarian Christian Social Union (CSU), challenges Schröder for the chancellorship, but fails in the general election to defeat the governing "red-green" coalition.

2003 Germany is extremely critical of the US–UK invasion of Iraq.

2005 In federal elections, no single party wins a majority, or is able to form a working coalition with the minority parties. The two main parties join a grand

coalition led by Angela Merkel, the CDU leader and first woman to become German chancellor.

2007 Germany holds both the rotating presidency of the EU and heads the G8 group of leading industrial nations, giving it unprecedented influence on the international stage.

2008 A huge fiscal stimulus package is agreed to counter the effects of the international financial crisis.

2009 Angela Merkel of the CDU-CSU wins the general election, with an increased number of seats but not an overall majority. She forms a coalition government with the Free Democrats (FDP). The German economy shrinks by 5 percent over the year.

«188–91 Medieval Europe

«256–59 The Reformation

«262–63 The 30 Years War

«386–87 Fascism

«390–91 Adolf Hitler

«400–01 The Holocaust

«426–27 The Berlin Wall

«448–49 Raising the Iron Curtain